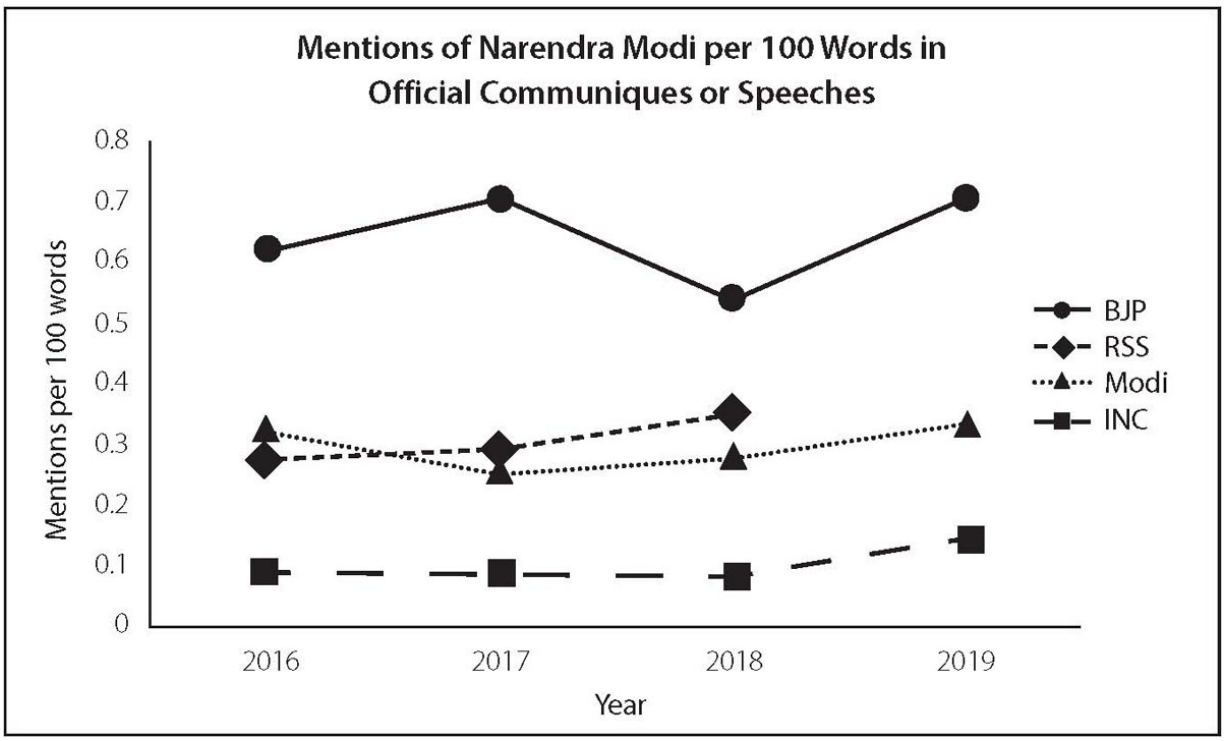


Source: Narad Index, Nalin Mehta and Rishabh Srivastava; for details see Appendix 4/online on nalinmehta.in.

The BJP is a political party that needs to win votes. The Sangh is linked to it in ideational terms but it is not in the business of electoral politics. This distinction impacts how the two organisations portray individual leaders. For the BJP, these leaders are vote catchers: Modi from 2014 onwards, Vajpayee in the 1990s and early 2000s.

Between 2016 and 2019, the RSS consistently spoke far more about the Ram Temple than either the BJP or Modi did. While the party's discourse was more about development, anti-Congressism and Pakistan (as detailed in Chapter 6), the Sangh did much of the heavy-lifting on hardcore 'Hindu' political issues (see Figures 13.3 and 13.4). In fact, the volume gap between their discourses on 'Hindu'-related issues and the Ram Temple is surprisingly large.

This suggests a useful political division, given the shared thinking of the RSS and BJP on wider cultural issues.

That the RSS speaks most about Hinduism is not surprising. This is, after all, an organisation where, in the words of a senior functionary, 'every swayamsevak takes the oath to work for "*Hindu*